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Original Article

The Variant Use of Verb in Pakistani English Newspapers: A Corpus-Based Study

¹Dr. Nazia Anwar, ²Isha Razzaq Butt & ³Ayesha Zuree

¹ Lecturer, Department of English, University of Gujrat, Email: nazia.anwar@uog.edu.pk

² MPhil Scholar, Department of English, University of Gujrat, Email: isharazzaq13@gmail.com

³ MPhil Linguistics, Department of English, University of Gujrat, Email: aysha.zuree.008@gmail.com

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*Corresponding Author:

Dr. Nazia Anwar
nazia.anwar@uog.edu.pk

ABSTRACT

The present study deals with the variable use of verb in Pakistani English. It describes the verbs in Pakistani English that are similar to Standard British English semantically but vary at lexical level. It is a qualitative descriptive study which intends to identify the lexical choices of PE speakers/ writers. Two corpora: BNC and PENC have been used in present study to identify and describe those verbs qualitatively and for studying nativization and variation in these verbs. While using the corpus of newspaper, the present study anticipates to recognize the lexical choices of Pakistani people which contribute in making Pakistani English a distinct variety. It also aims to ascertain the pragmatic aspects of Pakistani English that contribute to bring lexical changes in it.

Introduction

At the time of independence of Pakistan, English was declared its official language till the time of maturity of Urdu in Pakistan (Manan et al., 2017). Colonial missionaries have spread English language around the globe particularly in their colonies (Woodberry, 2012). Regional and local languages in such colonies added their flavors in English language. In addition, linguistic contact there has also produced different varieties of English language. Moreover, in Pakistan, English language has been also affected by its regional and local languages and emerged as a specific variety called Pakistani English (Parveen & Mahmood, 2013). According to Baumgardner (1993), localization of Pakistani English is under process and central reason of variation in the Pakistani English is the impact of local languages. Pakistani English targets to be considered its credibility as an independent variety.

Before the invention of printing press, there was no recognized form of Standard English. A perfect standard was not the requirement of that time (Johnson, 2010). Mostly the distinct

public writings were either in Latin or in French (ibid). With the advent of mechanized printing in late fifteenth century, certain standards were fixed for English language as a necessity. However, over the centuries, English language experienced many dynamic changes due to colonization, trade, wars and technology. Among those changes, semantic shift occupies the major place (Bernstein, 2010). As change is inherent to all languages, so the speakers of English language all over the world have made numerous changes to the English language. These changes took place at all levels including lexical, syntactical, morphological, semantic, phonemic etc.

According to Zaidi & Zaki (2017), in Pakistan, English language has been used as lingua franca. It enjoys the status of an official language along with Urdu (national language). It is the language of law and judiciary. Along with the regional and local languages, the effects of cultural, social and political situations in Pakistan have also contributed in making Pakistani English a distinct non-native variety. Its independent cultural and linguistic identity has been established (Zaidi & Zaki, 2017). This distinctive individuality of Pakistani English can be traced at grammatical as well as social level.

Variation is another name for such distinctiveness. According to Baumgardner (1993), variation in Pakistani English with respect to standard British English “—can be identified by certain distinctive linguistic features of grammar, word formation, lexical variation” (p, 258-259). Variation at the level of verb is quite prominent in Pakistani English and it is an important feature of Pakistani English. Talaat (1993) opines that use of standard British English exhibits a shift. According to Grover et al. (2004), linguistic features of Pakistani newspapers have been taken from local and regional languages for the successful transfer of meaning and better communication. English newspapers’ language in Pakistan is also prone to its social, cultural and political set up. Presence of local and regional linguistic features in English newspaper have brought variation in the use of different linguistic items at personal and societal level. According to Jilani and Anwar (2018), such variations are because of the deviance from the norms of standard British English which has lead to the distinctiveness of Pakistani English. Pakistani English is also a distinct variety of English language. Its particular features are needed to be identified (Mahboob & Elyas, 2014). There are certain researchers who have studied and elaborated the characteristic of Pakistani English including Talaat (2002, 1993, 1988) and Baumgardner (1995, 1993, 1992, 1990, 1988, 1987).

In English speaking community around the world, Pakistani English has been considered a new variety. Kachru (1983) has identified Pakistani English a variety of South Asian English but it lacks in certain areas i.e. standardization and codification. Variation in the use of verbs has not been studied adequately, particularly pertaining to lexical innovation which these variations in verbs use bring to Pakistani English. Present study has revealed the variable use of verb prevalent in Pakistani English and identified the verbs that are different to SBE at lexical level but are same semantically. These verbs have been nativized in Pakistani English and aids in making it a distinct variety. Present study has identified the lexical variations in verbs in Pakistani English and uncovered the similarity among semantic domains of different verbs in

SBE and PE. To achieve its objectives, the current study has focused to answer the following research questions:

1. How do the verbs in SBE and PE variate lexically?
2. How do different verbs in SBE and PE map on similar semantic domains?

Literature Review

According to Lecumberri et al. (2010), in non-native conditions, language functions depend on the need of its speakers and environment. Differences in conditions and environment cause transformation of language from one particular variety to another. The sources which are the major vehicle for such promotion and transformation of language are modern ways of communication particularly electronic and print media (Simon, 2013). Newspaper in today's life is one of the most modern means of communication. This norm of news paper's importance is globally accepted. Therefore, newspapers in Pakistan have been also considered as one of the most important methods of language promotion. Upgrade of language in Pakistan has made Pakistani English a variety supposed to be accepted, a variety which is different to the native variety (Yousaf et al., 2016). This is a chain of linguistic change that keeps on adding in today's world of globalization. Such changes in language become logical when we see it with the lens of linguistic change globally. It not only adds into the change in languages but also the overall richness of language is also increased.

Grover et al. (2004) has explained that an effective communication not only requires the ability to talk and write fluently but also the ability to make one understood and to understand others. Linguists have different approaches and viewpoints about the changes in language in non-native territories. Purists according to Kachru (1992) are in favor of the use of a single common language around the world. They claim that if the non-native speakers are given the control of future of language, it will be disintegrated and incomprehensible language is the only thing that will be left out there. Sociolinguistic aspects of English in its international context are still not well understood (Eckert, 2008). According to Hussain (2002) when any language goes from one territory to another it flourishes from all sides.

Undoubtedly, English has made its mark on the global linguistic map, initially through colonialism and in the post-colonial era, as an international mode of communication on the internet for millions of people in spread in every geographical region of the world. It was not until the 1980s that the study of the unique and distinct regional variations of English language were studied by linguistic researchers (Bailey and Gorlach, 1982; Platt et al., 1984; Kachru, 1986, 1992). The seminal work by Schneider (2003, 2007) has provided a conceptual model for the development of local, socially and culturally-distinct varieties of 'English' in the different regions of the world, which were once colonized by the British Empire and now operate in an independent capacity towards the evolution of local variants of 'English'. These regions of the world with their 'Englishes' provide a unique insight into the evolution of foreign languages and their adoption and assimilation with the regional languages as well as cultural norms and values (Lo Bianco, 2010). In this regard, Schneider's model (2007) is an attempt to understand the underlying social, cultural and political factors that shape the formation of new 'Englishes' as

lexically, phonetically and linguistically different from British English from the period of colonization to the post-colonization era of the present times.

According to Schneider's (2007) model, the five stages of development of local-level 'Englishes' can be charted as follows: (i) foundation (the original English is introduced to the foreign region through physical contact with native language speakers in the shape of military expansion, trade, missionary activities and emigration). (ii) exonormative stabilization (the political stability of colonial activity is ensured, leading to full exposure between English language of the colonizers and local customs, culture and languages). (iii) nativization (the political influence diminishes, but the linguistic and cultural presence is maintained through regular interaction between former colonials and local English speaking population). (iv) endonormative stabilization (the local variety of English is socially accepted in the society and has established a stable linguistic identity, which contains rich local social, cultural and linguistic influences), and (v) differentiation (the socio-political stability of the young nation post-independence leads to the development of complex networks, leading to formation of local dialects of English language).

In each of the five stages of transformation and evolution of new 'Englishes', Schneider (2007) has focused on examining the historical and political landscape of the local region, identity construction, attitudes, contact and usage of a developed language, as well as its development and structural impact. Within this particular research, Schneider (2007) model will be incorporated in order to study the evolution of Pakistani English from the time of arrival of British colonial rulers in the Subcontinent to the present day. According to Gargesh (2019), Pakistani English is a variety in itself, it has its own flavor, vocabulary, grammar and it is considered to be a different variety having its own flavor. Pakistani English is different from standard British English in its use of adjectives and verbs also. While studying its growth in Pakistan, the variation in the use of verbs in Pakistani English cannot be ignored. Verbs patterns in Pakistani English have greatly contributed in making it a new nonnative variety (ibid).

Variations among new varieties of English have been regarded as creativities. Variations always come from the social, cultural and political variations in particular region (Aijmer, 2014). According to Baumgardner (2006), the impact of English language is "all pervasive" (p.36). Since the creation of Pakistan, English has been the national and official language. It has been used in all spheres of life in Pakistan. Schneider and Zipp (2013) have studied different patterns of verbs existing around the world. They have illustrated the verb and preposition combination in Fiji and Indian English. The current study has identified the variation in the use of verb in SBE and PE. It has also described the Pakistani English and lexical innovation pertaining to the alternative use of verbs by Pakistani news editors.

Materials and Methods

For present study, six newspapers of one month of September for the year 2015 have been selected to build the corpus: 1) Daily Times, 2) Dawn ,3) Frontier Post, 4) Nation, 5) The News, 6) The Post. A corpus of 5 million words has been composed to check the verbs used in Pakistani English newspapers carrying the same meanings as in SBE but with new lexical items.

A list of fifty verbs has been randomly selected from the book “Indian and British English” (Nihalani, Tongue, Hosali, & Crowther 1979). From this randomly developed list of verbs, only those verbs that occurred more than twenty times in corpus have been analyzed qualitatively. Co-text for the qualitatively analyzed examples is same for BNC and PE. Antconc 3.2.1 software tool for corpus analysis has identified those verbs along with the co-text. British national corpus (BNC) has been used as a source to check equivalent verbs in standard British English (SBE) for bringing out the lexical difference established in Pakistani English.

Theoretical framework

Schneider’s Dynamic Model of the evolution of Postcolonial Englishes has been used as framework in present study. It has five succeeding stages named as foundation, exonormative stabilization, nativization, endonormative stabilization and differentiation (Schneider 2007:30). In the current study, the third phase i.e. nativization, (Schneider 2007: 40-48) is the most important phase. At this stage, reformation of English has been conceded and new variety of postcolonial English i.e. Pakistani English has emerged. Pakistani English is a postcolonial variety of English. It is considered as a distinct variety as expressed earlier. Pakistani English variety is at this stage of nativization. New variety is in process of making and adding new feature. Nativization of certain linguistic items has been done and Pakistani English has its regional and cultural bases. Present study intends to explore the nativized patterns of verbs used in Pakistani English newspapers. For this purpose, this model is the most suitable model.

Data analysis

Use of verbs in Pakistani English is different s compared to standard British English. It has variable patterns. In the present study, verbs in PE that are semantically same but different to SBE at lexical level are identified. These verbs are described qualitatively in following lines:

Table 1: Details of Verbs with news lexical items by Pakistani Users

PE	Dawn	The News	Daily Times	Nation	Frontier Post	The Post	Total
Enhance	495	540	530	505	415	465	2950
Blamed	485	535	520	490	402	463	2895
Eliminate	449	529	490	460	382	443	2753
Weeping	424	504	465	445	372	435	2645
Suggest	401	479	440	430	370	423	2543
Delivers	351	429	390	380	335	393	2278
Boarded	55	49	53	65	40	37	299
Dashed	45	43	46	35	44	40	253
Apt	44	43	45	35	43	38	248

Hail	42	44	43	33	41	36	239
Deputed	40	42	41	31	39	34	227
Repent	41	42	40	31	39	32	225
Brake	41	42	40	31	39	31	224
Charge-sheeted	40	40	40	31	39	31	221

Table 2: Verbs in Pakistani English with new lexical items but same meaning

PE	Frequency
Enhance	2950
Blamed	2895
Eliminate	2753
weeping	2645
Suggest	2543
Delivers	2278
Boarded	299
Dashed	253
Apt	248
Hail	239
Deputed	227
Repent	225
Brake	224
Charge-sheeted	221

Examples

1. At the same time however, there has been an apparent failure of past land reforms to **enhance** productivity or to achieve large-scale land redistributions. (Dawn.Sep.txt.2015).
2. He said adding that lowering prices not only help the customers but would also **enhance** the sales of the company. (Nation.Sep.txt. 2015).
3. Scottish captain Ryan Watson **blamed** his batsman for the defeat. (Nation. Sep txt. 2015)
4. The officials have **blamed** red-tapism for the delay. (News.Sep.txt. 2015.)
5. Once a virus or Trojan appears, even if it is hidden in other programs, Anti-Virus and Trojan will display a warning signal and **eliminate** it consequently. (The News.Sep.txt. 2015).
6. The EU is offering to **eliminate** duties on 72 percent of bilateral trade immediately once an agreement is signed but Korea is offering only 45 percent, an EU officer has said. (Nation.Sep.txt. 2015).

7. The crowd, many of them **weeping**, stood and erupted into applause as Lambert left the bench. (Dawn.Sep.txt. 2015).
8. They also pay tributes to the deceased and praise him or her by all the available words but no one is seen **weeping** or mourning. (Frontier Post.Sep.txt. 2015).
9. But it does strongly **suggest** the need to cultivate a more tolerant attitude towards our fellow human beings. (News.Sep.txt. 2015).
10. I **suggest** you disable all but the most requires programs. (The Post.Sep.txt. 2015).
11. Pressed for details, she said she **delivers** food and water to captives and escorts them from their cells to recreation yards. (Dawn.Sep.txt. 2015).
12. But our education system also **delivers** education of such poor quality that most of those who complete primary, secondary or higher education still remain essentially completely ignorant about many of the factors that most influence their lives. (The Post.Sep.txt. 2015).
13. Recently when I **boarded** a plane to Karachi after a short-day visit to Islamabad, people were asked to switch off their cellular phones. (The Post.Sep.txt. 2015)
14. Nawaz **boarded** the Pakistan international airlines flight PK-786 to Islamabad at London's Heathrow airport. (Nation.Sep.txt. 2015).
15. A minor was killed when two motorcycle riders **dashed** into each other near Iqra university in Korangi. (Nation.Sep.txt. 2015).
16. According to details, a speedy wagon no R-016 **dashed** a cyclist Arshad. (The News.Sep.txt. 2015).
17. It was perhaps an **apt** comment on case that followed the killing of Mir Murtaza Bhutto and his companions that took place 11 years ago on Sept 20, 1996. (News.Sep.txt. 2015).
18. This is an **apt** introduction for the first Gulf War is often seen as the defining moment of the Post-Cold War World. (Dawn.Sep.txt. 2015).
19. Mainly the students are disinterested because they **hail** from families where education is not given much importance. (Frontier Post.Sep.txt. 2015).
20. Basically, I and my husband **hail** from a town near Multan. (Nation.Sep.txt. 2015).
21. The court **deputed** a bailiff who raided the area with the local police and recovered Adnan for Nasir's custody. (The Post.Sep.txt. 2015).
22. The DPO has **deputed** special team to trace the robbers. (Dawn.Sep.txt. 2015).
23. If you do indulge in that nefarious activity, back you go to Jeddah to **repent** for your intended or unintended sins for the rest of your life. (Nation.Sep.txt. 2015).
24. India will **repent** in case of any adventure against Pakistan. (The News.Sep.txt. 2015).

25. Unsold rickshaws put a **brake** to Rozgar Scheme: partners reluctant to continue project. (Frontier Post.Sep.txt.2015) .
26. This, particularly trucks, makes it hard to control, especially when they need to **brake**. (Dawn.Sep.txt. 2015).
27. The court has **charge-sheeted** 10 people. (Dawn.Sep.txt. 2015).
28. But the MD has been **charge-sheeted** by Khawaja Asif. (Frontier Post.Sep.txt. 2015).

Explanation

In examples 1 & 2, it is apparent that in SBE the verb **enhance** means ‘to increase or further improve the good quality, value or status of’ something, not physical size, amount or magnitude’ (Oxford dictionary, 1948). Speakers of SBE would probably prefer ‘**increase**’ in the above cited example because increase is used where an increase in amount, size or degree has been anticipated as in the above examples. In examples 3 & 4, it is shown, When **blamed** is used in SBE “someone is normally being censured for the result or consequence of some action which he has taken or failed to take” (Oxford dictionary, 1948). Furthermore, the event or circumstance for which the person is being blamed is normally stated or implied. Moreover, it has been used when someone or something is declared responsible for the fault. Thus, in above stated context **criticized** will be preferred in SBE. Because criticize is also used when “the faults of (someone or something) in a disapproving way are indicated” (Oxford dictionary, 1948). In examples 5 & 6, the researcher has identified that the verb **eliminate** is used with quite a large number of collocates in SBE, meaning “to remove or to get rid of” (Oxford dictionary, 1948). But it has been never used with the viruses. **Remove** would more likely to be used instead in SBE. In PE it is used with a large number of collocates including the one cited above.

In examples 7 & 8, it is evident that the verb **weeping** is very commonly used in variable contexts in PE. While in SBE the verb **crying** has been used preferably in such contexts. In examples 9 & 10, the verb **suggest** has been used. This manner of using the verb **suggest** is frequent among PE speakers. **Suggest** means “Put forward for consideration” (Oxford dictionary, 1948). The sentence cannot be possible in SBE. The use of verb **advise** is recurrent instead in SBE which is defined as “Offer suggestions about the best course of action to someone” (Oxford dictionary, 1948). In examples 11 & 12, it is identified by the researcher that in SBE, **delivers** is always used with lectures and speeches. It is defined as “Bring and hand over (a letter, parcel, or goods) to the proper recipient or address” (Oxford dictionary, 1948). While for the contexts given above **gives** is used in SBE whereas it has been regularly used in PE in above cited circumstances. Give is defined as “Take or go with (someone or something) to a place” (Oxford dictionary, 1948). In examples, 13 & 14, the study has found that In SBE, verb **boarded** is used in formal circumstances. Instead **get on** is used more recurrently in SBE while it is very regularly used by PE speakers both in formal and informal settings. Both of these verbs mean same in SBE and PE. In examples 15 & 16, it has been indicated that in PE verb **dash** is very frequently used for vehicles and humans while in SBE **hit** is used for the vehicles striking anything for the same circumstances. It is defined as “Bring one's hand or a tool or weapon into contact with (someone

or something) quickly and forcefully” (Oxford dictionary, 1948). Therefore, both verbs are semantically same.

In examples 17 & 18, it has been elucidated that in SBE, a person is considered good or convincing for the role he/she plays or views he expresses about something. Oxford dictionary (1948) defines *Apt* as “Appropriate or suitable in the circumstances”. In PE, apt is used quite frequently for the same thing. In the given example, meaning may be that the comment was very good or convincing that underlines the sense of causing someone to believe that something is true or real. In examples 19 & 20, it is clarified that the verb hail may seem old fashioned to SBE speakers; they will prefer to use come instead. Hail is defined as “Move or travel towards or into a place thought of as near or familiar to the speaker” (Oxford dictionary, 1948). It is regularly used in PE. In examples 21 & 22, it is expressed that the verb *deputed* is more commonly used in PE than in SBE. According to Oxford dictionary *deputed* is defined as “Appoint or instruct (someone) to perform a task for which one is responsible” (Oxford dictionary, 1948). In SBE, it has somewhat formal and ancient flavor. In SBE the verb ‘instructed or ordered’ would probably be used in above cited context. In examples 23 & 24, it is obvious that the verb *repent* is usually followed by a direct object in SBE, so use of for is considered superfluous in SBE. It means “Feel or express sincere regret or remorse about one's wrongdoing or sin” (Oxford dictionary, 1948). It is also used in more formal circumstances in SBE than PE. SBE speakers will use regretted in the example quoted. Which means “Feel sad, repentant, or disappointed over (something that one has done or failed to do) (Oxford dictionary, 1948).” In examples 25 & 26, it has been revealed that the verb brake is used imperatively in PE with reference to vehicle and as a noun to qualify other nouns as well. It is defined as “make a moving vehicle slow down or stop by using a brake” (Oxford dictionary, 1948) while in SBE verb stop is preferred in given example because it has the same meaning. In examples 27 & 28, it has been indicated that the verb *charge-sheeted* does not exist in SBE, In SBE offenders are either charged or their names are placed on the charge-sheet. It is very often used in PE in same context.

Conclusion

The present study has identified that PE varies from SBE a great deal in its use of verb. In current study, verbs in Pakistani English with new lexical items but same meaning are identified and described qualitatively. This variation in the use of verb depicts the difference in lexical choices of Pakistani news editors. The study expresses that selection of certain verbs over others by the news editors is random. This disparity also pertains to the subjective attitude of news writers which depicts that Pakistani news writers use more emotional and catchy language to enhance the intensity of the situation. The use of the verb *blamed* instead of *criticized* in present study is an example of such lexical choices. The identified distinct verb patterns have been nativized and contribute in making Pakistani English a unique and distinctive variety. Moreover, Language has many features. It varies at grammatical, lexical, syntactic and pragmatic levels. It is hard to cover all these areas in present study. It only focuses on the variation in the use of verb in Pakistani English newspapers.

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